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Prepare for success in your viva

Expectations for today's workshop

- It's an interactive workshop – you do the work, we guide you.
- Listen actively to us and each other throughout.



Intended learning outcomes

By the end of the workshop, you will know more about and have had practice in:

- developing a clear narrative with a logical structure and clear slides
- guiding your audience through the content (language and voice)
- responding to questions clearly and thoroughly
- exploring the CfAE's wider provision

Intended learning outcomes

By the end of the workshop, you will know more about and have had practice in:

- **developing a clear narrative with a logical structure and clear slides**
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What to consider before a presentation: presenting your project

1. What is the context/setting (how might I adapt my presentation accordingly)?

in your department / in a public speaking event / **in an assessment** / at a conference

2. What is the purpose (not just what's expected of me, but what I want to achieve)?

to disseminate information / **to pass an assessment** / to garner support, input and interest / to persuade sponsors, funders, prospective employers

3. Who is the audience? (how can I engage them and make the content accessible?)

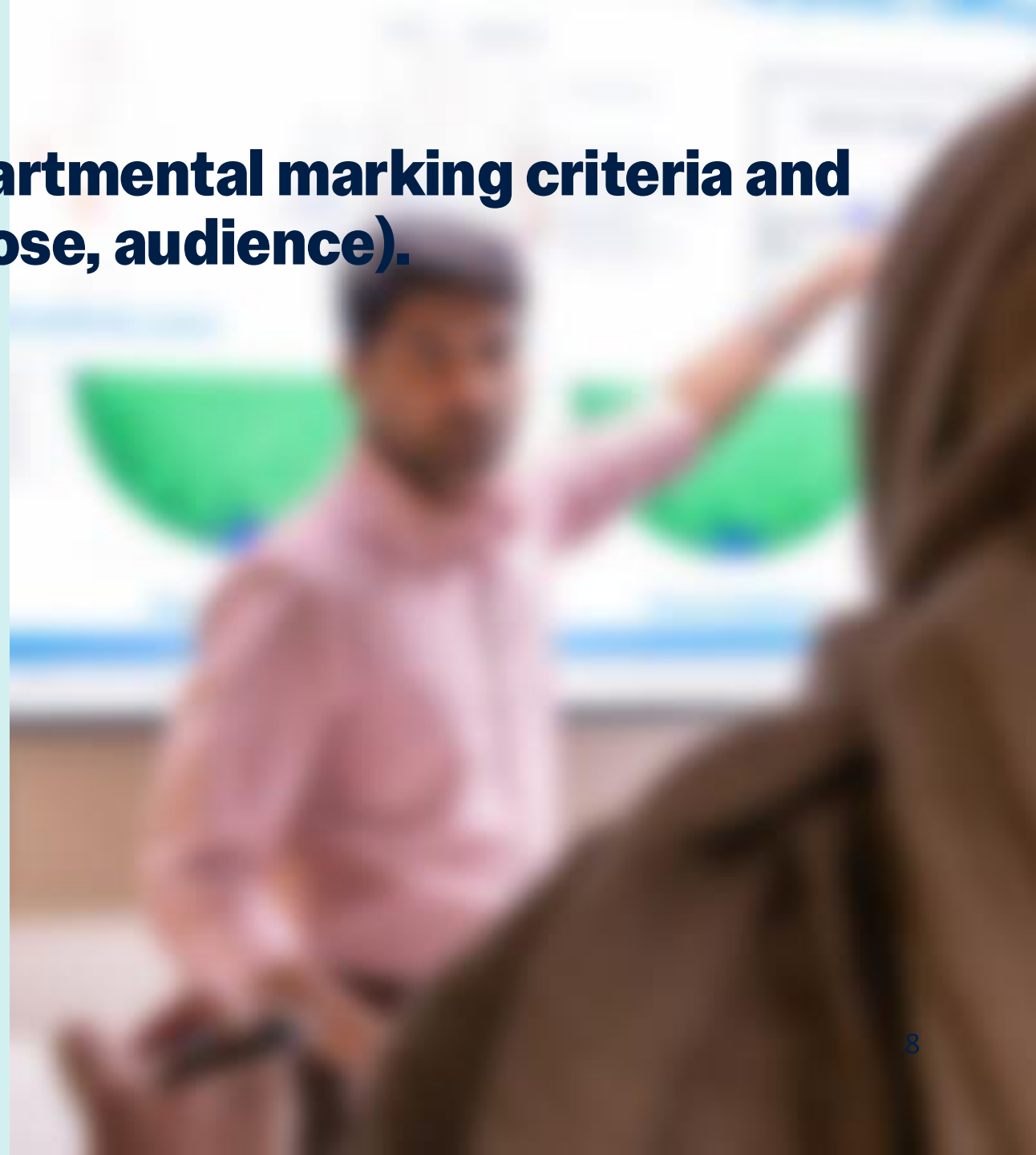
experts OR non-experts (peers, senior academics, lay audience, government) /

assessors / gatekeepers, investors, key stakeholders

Task 1: Understanding your departmental marking criteria and what's expected (context, purpose, audience).

Discuss with a partner

1. When will your viva take place?
2. What's the format and how long will you have?
3. Who's in the audience and what's their role?
4. How far should your project report and presentation link? What should you include in your presentation?
5. What are you being assessed on and how can you achieve top grades?



Your presentation needs a clear narrative

Contextualise the need for this research

What were your research questions/aims?

How did you approach this and why?

What did you find?

Have you answered your research questions?/To what extent did you achieve your measurable research aims?

Contextualise the impact of the research

Top tips from assessors: don't just list what you did; outline the project aims to explain the project output

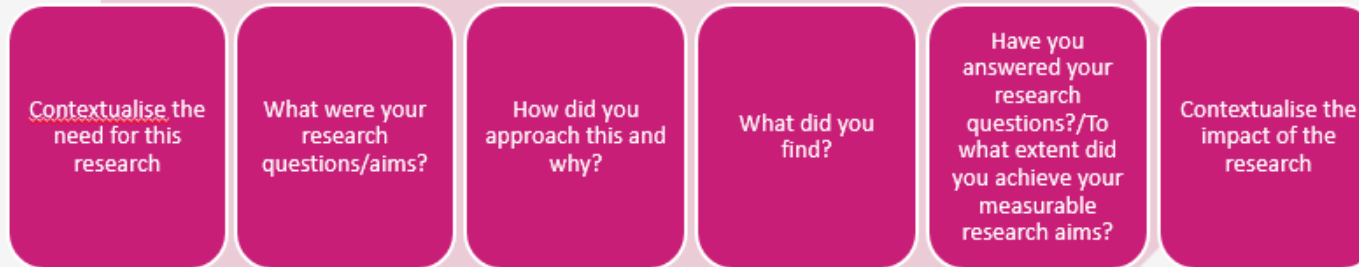
Don't just list a series of tasks you carried out, without a specific connection between them nor vision about the overall aim of the project.

Do set out clearly what the overall research question was, and how the outcome has been validated

Do clearly outline the measurable research aims of your project at the beginning of your presentation, and refer back to them at the end in order to demonstrate that what you did has been successful

Choosing what to include: what is the function of this slide, and does it add value?

Your presentation needs a clear narrative



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Choosing what to include: what is the best way to present the information?

1.

Distributivity - Definition

The distributive property of multiplication over addition is simply this: it makes no difference whether you add two or more terms together first, and then multiply the results by a factor, or whether you multiply each term alone by the factor first, and then add up the results.

2.

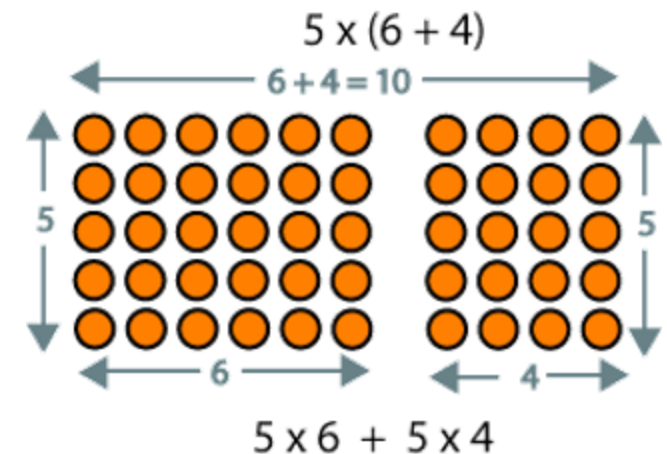
Distributivity

Multiplication is distributive over addition

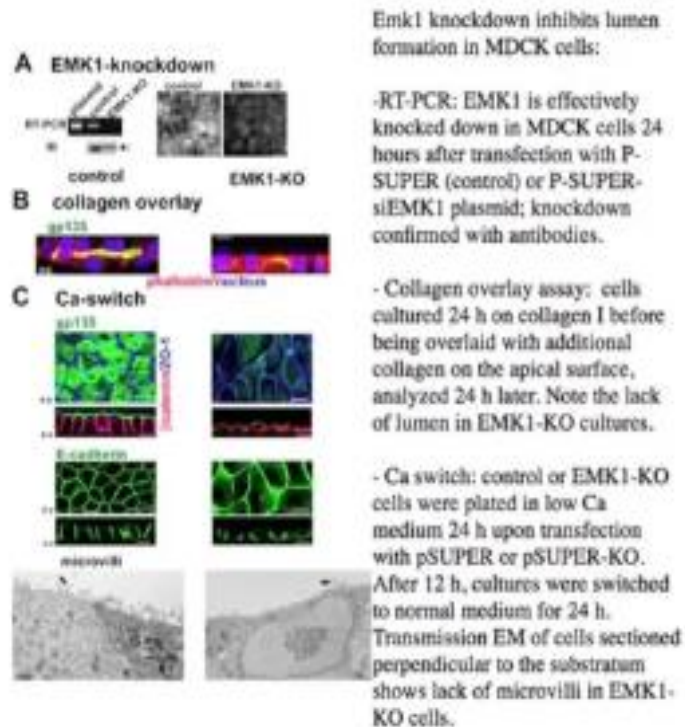
- $a(b+c) = ab + ac$
- $(a+b)(c+d) = ac + ad + bc + bd$

3.

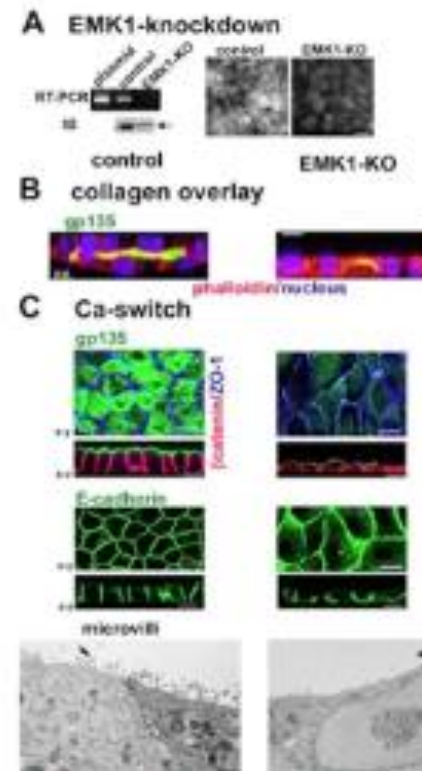
Distributivity



What are some of the key considerations when designing slides?

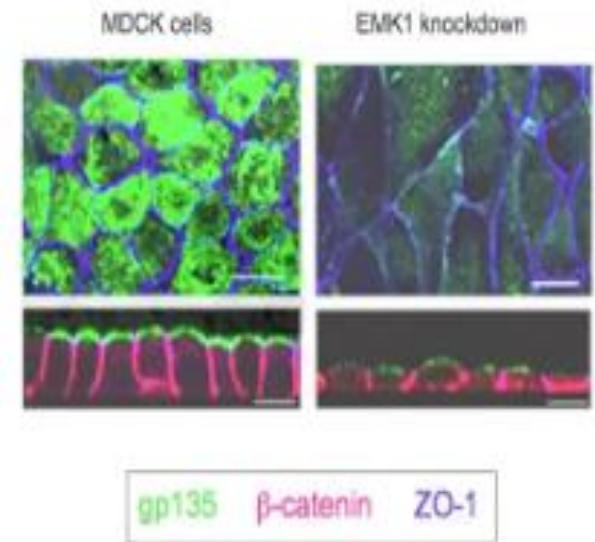


Susan McConnell, (Stanford) Designing Effective Scientific Pres...



Susan McConnell, (Stanford) Designing Eff...

Lumen formation is blocked in EMK1 knockdown cells



Susan McConnell, (Stanford) Designing Effective...

Task 2a: Look at the slides you've brought with you today.

Discuss with a partner

1. What is the purpose of each of your slides? What 'value' does this slide add to your presentation?
2. Have you shown the information in the optimal way? (text, visual, video clip etc)?
3. Are your slides designed well? (quantity of information, font, colour choice, legends, heading etc.)

Task 2b: Presenting slides.

Choose one slide and present it to a new partner

Step 1: Introduce yourself, your department, the title of your project and explain where this slide ‘sits’ in your presentation.

Step 2: Present your slide

- “And here are...” “This image/table/diagram shows...”
- “The x axis represents...” “...shown in blue here.” “We can clearly see the sharp rise in...”
- “What’s especially interesting is...” “...meaning my stated objectives were met and...” “The main point here is...”

Task 2b: Presenting slides.

Give feedback on the clarity of the slide and how your partner explained the content

1. Give feedback on what was positive:

- The diagram was useful for understanding...
- I thought the way you... was particularly strong/clear/helpful

2. And offer some constructive criticism (and advice):

- I struggled to follow you as you jumped into the detail without explaining what I was looking at.
- It would have helped me if you'd...



Task 2b: Presentation (2 mins) and peer review (1 min) x 2 (6 mins)

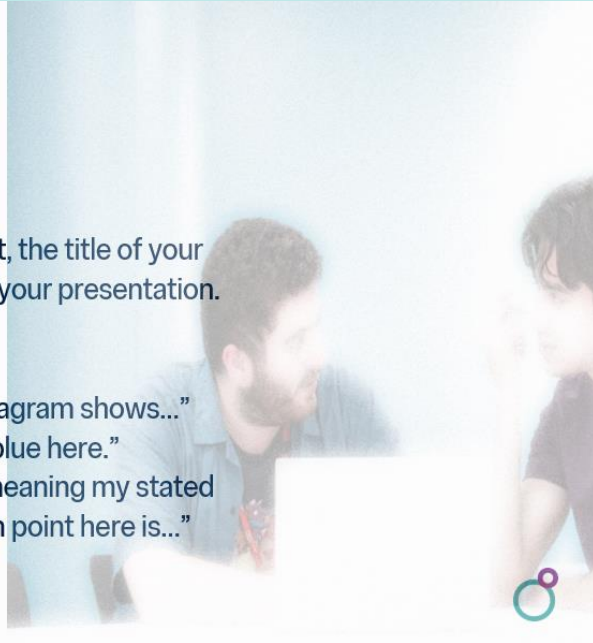
Task 3b: Presenting slides. Choose one slide and present it to a new partner

Step 1: Introduce yourself, your department, the title of your project and explain where this slide 'sits' in your presentation.

Step 2: Present your slide

- "And here are..." "This image/table/diagram shows..."
- "The x axis represents..." "...shown in blue here."
- "What's especially interesting is..." "...meaning my stated objectives were met and..." "The main point here is..."

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Task 3b: Presenting slides. Give feedback on the clarity of the slide and how your partner explained the content

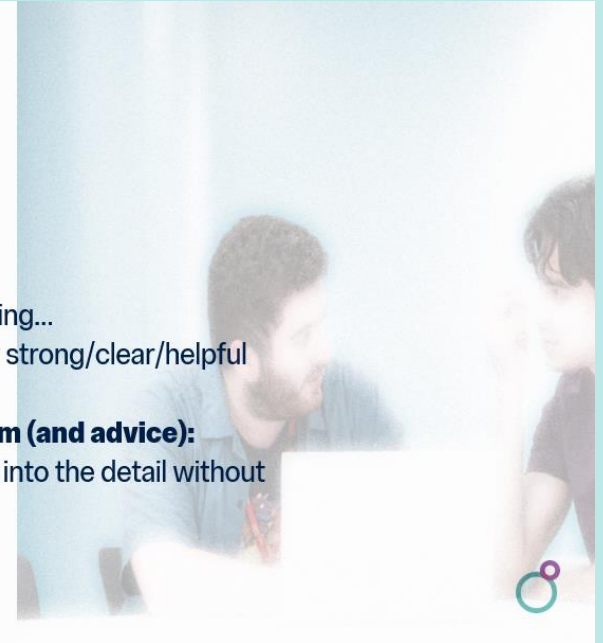
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- I struggled to follow you as you jumped into the detail without explaining what I was looking at.
- It would have helped me if you'd...

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Reflection and personal action points on planning and slide design

What is your main takeaway from this part of the session? Did you know this before?

What might you do differently when planning and designing slides?



Intended learning outcomes

By the end of the workshop, you will know more about and have had practice in:

- developing a clear narrative with a logical structure and clear slides
- **guiding your audience through the content (language and voice)**
- responding to questions clearly and thoroughly
- exploring the CfAE's wider provision

Guiding your audience effectively through the content: **language**

Our planet faces the challenge of global warming...

In light of increasing worldwide energy consumption, it is increasingly therefore crucial to look for alternatives to fossil resources.

One of these alternatives may be the energy of tides

Guiding your audience effectively through the content: language

Our planet faces the challenge of global warming...

In light of increasing worldwide energy consumption, it is increasingly therefore crucial to look for alternatives to fossil resources.

One of these alternatives may be the energy of tides

Guiding your audience through the narrative: **language to demonstrate relevance, impact, significance, potential etc.**

Our planet **faces the challenge** of global warming...

In light of **increasing worldwide energy consumption**, **it is increasingly** therefore **crucial** to look for alternatives to fossil resources.

One of these alternatives **may be the energy of tides**

Task 3: How to guide your listener through your presentation and keep the audience with you

Work in pairs or threes. Open the Form.

Read the 6 extracts from presentations.

Decide what the speaker is doing in each extract.

Then suggest other ways in which you might guide your listener through your presentation and 'keep them with you'.

Task 4: How to guide your listener through your presentation (August 20)



<https://forms.office.com/e/P4mc2M20w6>

Guiding your audience through the content: **voice**

Listen to the first minute of an Imperial PhD student's presentation.

What does Tobias do with his voice to communicate his message more clearly?

Guiding your audience through the content: **voice**

- He **emphasises** key ideas/terms/information (stronger, longer, lower or higher)
- He **pauses** ahead of key ideas/terms/information
- He **pauses** to allow the listener to take in information
- He **slows down** on key information (changes speed)
- He **moves his voice** to engage and guide
 - ✓ **down** at the end of a sentence on facts [...and it's a big one], at the end of a list [...and individual positioning for turbines]
 - ✓ **up** on introducing an idea [One of these...], contrast [However], first items in a list [location, number...]

Task 4: Guiding your audience

Present slides to your partner (3 minutes): transitions, guiding and voice

Take four minutes to rehearse how you can best guide your partner through your slides. Consider both guiding language and using your voice to emphasise, show contrast etc.

Each of you take three minutes to present at least two slides. You should refer to an imagined preceding slide and an imagined next slide.



Task 4: Presenting slides.

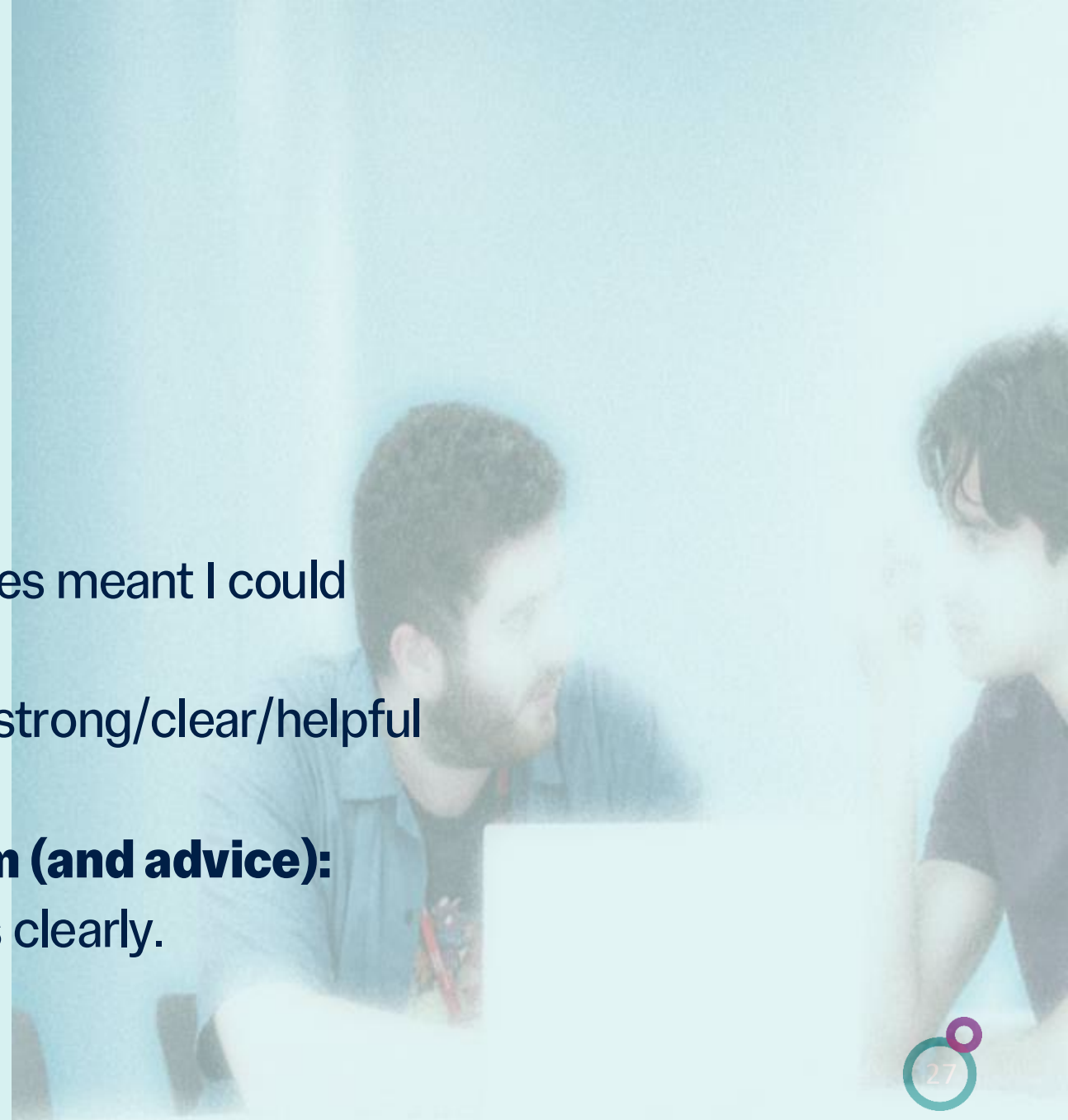
Give feedback on guiding language and the voice

1. Give feedback on what was positive:

- The way you guided us between the slides meant I could easily follow the narrative.
- I thought the way you... was particularly strong/clear/helpful

2. And offer some constructive criticism (and advice):

- I couldn't hear all of your technical terms clearly.
- It would have helped me if you'd...



Task 4: Presentation (4 mins) and peer review (1 min) x 2 (10 mins)

Task 4: Guiding your audience Present slides to your partner (3 minutes): transitions, guiding and voice

Take four minutes to rehearse how you can best guide your partner through your slides. Consider both guiding language and using your voice to emphasise, show contrast etc.

Each of you take three minutes to present at least two slides. You should refer to an imagined preceding slide and an imagined next slide.

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Task 4: Presenting slides. Give feedback on guiding language and the voice

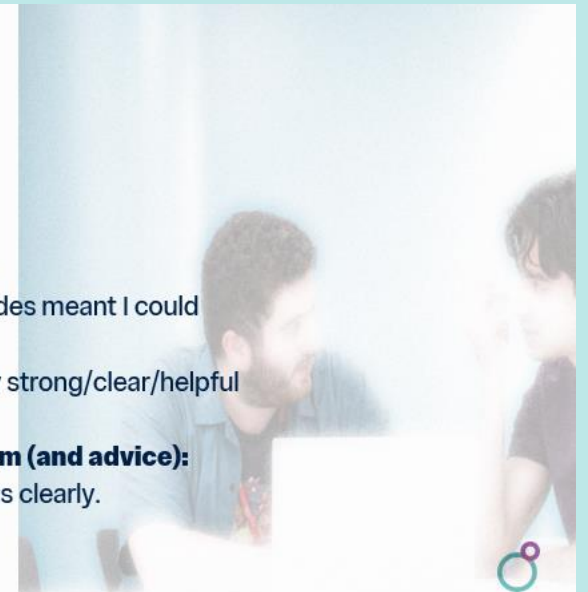
1. Give feedback on what was positive:

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2. And offer some constructive criticism (and advice):

- I couldn't hear all of your technical terms clearly.
- It would have helped me if you'd...

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Reflection and personal action points on guiding the audience through the content

What is your main takeaway from this part of the session? Did you know this before?

What might you do differently when rehearsing and delivering your presentation?



Intended learning outcomes

By the end of the workshop, you will know more about and have had practice in:

- developing a clear narrative with a logical structure and clear slides
- guiding your audience through the content (language and voice)
- **responding to questions clearly and thoroughly**
- exploring the CfAE's wider provision

Understanding what the assessor is looking for so you can respond clearly, effectively and thoroughly

"Which one is better: to show us all the results or just the average?"

Is the assessor asking you to:

clarify, add detail, address gaps, critically evaluate, critically reflect *or* consider bigger picture?

Understanding what the assessor is looking for so you can respond clearly, effectively and thoroughly

"Which one is better: to show us all the results or just the average?"

Is the assessor asking you to:

clarify, add detail, address gaps, critically evaluate, **critically reflect** *or* consider bigger picture?

Task 5: Identifying question types

Task 5: Question types (August 20)



<https://forms.office.com/e/jnyzcsCYZC>

Open the Form. Discuss the questions in pairs or threes.

Match each pair of questions with one of the six common question types we've been looking at.

Employing strategies to ensure you answer questions clearly and effectively

"Right. And with asthma control, does a single person's voice vary enough that you actually need to train against their own audio? So, if I record over and over into this and give that feedback, would the model get better vs a general population?"

Sorry, are you asking...? / So, do you mean...? / If I've understood fully, you're asking...?

So that's XXX. What was the second part of your question again, please? / Does that answer everything?

Ah, great question. So, ../ Right, the **outcomes**. Well, ../ Hm, that's difficult to say, but..

Past viva questions. Which questions 'fit' your project? What questions might you anticipate and how can you prepare?

What was your metric for success, and do you think you've achieved it?

Can you take us through the motivation for the project once more?

Can you take us through any area you might have struggled a bit?

How much did you gain from working on this project?

What assumptions did you make at the start of this project?

Why did you choose this particular method/approach/tool?

Why didn't you use [method/material X]?

If you'd done [X] instead of [Y], what would have been the effect?

Can you tell us some of the barriers to using this tech to scale?

Mmm hmm. I always prefer a tangible example, so could you give me an example?

How do these variables compare?

Task 6: answering questions effectively Ping pong Q&A

Past viva questions. Which questions 'fit' your project? What questions might you anticipate and how can you prepare?

What was your metric for success, and do you think you've achieved it?
Can you take us through the motivation for the project once more?
Can you take us through any area you might have struggled a bit?
How much did you gain from working on this project?
What assumptions did you make at the start of this project?
Why did you choose this particular method/approach/tool?
Why didn't you use [method/material X]?
If you'd done [X] instead of [Y], what would have been the effect?
Can you tell us some of the barriers to using this tech to scale?
Mmm hmm. I always prefer a tangible example, so could you give me an example?
How do these variables compare?

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Employing strategies to ensure you answer questions clearly and effectively

"Right. And with asthma control, does a single person's voice vary enough that you actually need to train against their own audio? So, if I record over and over into this and give that feedback, would the model get better vs a general population?"

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Intended learning outcomes 4

By the end of the workshop, you will know more about and have had practice in:

- fulfilling the departmental learning outcomes for your project report
- developing a clear narrative with a logical structure
- responding to questions clearly and thoroughly
- **exploring the CfAE's wider provision**

CfAE personal dashboard

First, select the relevant tab. Then, construct your personalised pathway by adding (+) learning blocks from the left panel to the right panel. To help you prioritise, when you click on a STEM and dropping. After adding a block to your pathway, click play (▶) to then start it in a new window. The pathway shows which blocks are in progress (🟡) and which have been completed

If you can't see the progress of a block in your personalised pathway, it may help to refresh (🔄) the page. You can return to the main Blackboard course page (🏠) at any point.

Effective STEM texts	Lab reports	Literature reviews	Dissertations	Research papers	Essays	Speaking and listening	Personalised pathway
Learning blocks: STEM communication task focus							
+ Poster presentations ▶ + PowerPoint presentations ▶ + Listening to lectures ▶ + CfAE group activities & 1:1 advice ▶							
Learning blocks: fundamentals of STEM communication							
+ Handling questions effectively ▶ + Guiding and engaging an audience ▶ + Using body language to improve communication ▶ + Using my voice effectively ▶ + Understanding verbal instructions ▶ + Understanding unfamiliar voices ▶ + Coping with fast speech ▶ + Speech shadowing ▶							

and 1:1s

Receive 1:1 speaking or listening advice



Book a 1:1 session with a CfAE coach

Not sure how to get started improving your communication?
Or maybe you want to receive targeted advice on
your speaking or listening in particular?

Book your 1:1 now! >

In our 20-minute sessions you can:

- ask a CfAE coach for general guidance on how to improve your academic speaking or listening
- check which resources you would most benefit from
- share a short sample of your work (e.g. assessed presentation or viva preparation) if you feel it would benefit the discussion

<https://bb.imperial.ac.uk/ultra/>

<http://imperial.ac.uk/academic-english/speaking/advice/>

Key action points from today's workshop

1. Design/revise a presentation that aligns both with the departmental guidance and with what we've covered today on developing a narrative and guiding your (mixed) audience through the content
2. Check out the CfAE self-study learning blocks on (PowerPoint presentations, Guiding and Engaging an audience, Using my voice effectively, Handling questions effectively)
3. Prepare for the post-presentation discussion, paying particular attention to what we've covered on understanding question types and ensuring your responses demonstrate the key communication skills we've focussed on
4. Rehearse **effectively** (both presentation delivery and the discussion). If feasible/desirable, practise with a colleague - the authentic questions from slide 29 might be useful

Please complete the evaluation form

CfAE evaluation survey



Q5: Which of the following did you attend?

- A workshop for a department or research group

Q6: Which CfAE workshop/one-off session have you just completed?

- Prepare for success in your viva (19 August)

<https://forms.office.com/e/gvWJpwNSB1>